



Discovering Genetics



What is genetics? Who made some of the first discoveries into genetics? Genetics is the study of genes and heredity. Genetics helps us understand how living organisms, like people and animals, inherit traits from their parents. Offspring might resemble their parents, but they are not usually exactly the same as them. Genetics helps to explain this.

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Gregor Mendel is often described as being the “father of genetics”. He was an Austrian monk and a scientist in the mid 1800s, who studied the inheritance of traits. At this time, no one knew about genes or chromosomes.

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Mendel experimented with pea plants in his garden by cross-breeding them. Mendel observed physical traits that appeared more often in the plants. He called these traits ‘dominant’ traits. ‘Recessive’ traits were the traits that did not occur as often.

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Mendel proved with his pea plants that genetic traits were inherited from the parents. He showed that there were patterns of inheritance between generations.

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Mendel discovered that there were rules for how certain traits passed from one generation of pea plants to the next. The genetic rules he discovered were a milestone in the study of genetics.

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Mendel experimented with thousands of pea plants for over almost a decade. But, he was a scientist who was ahead of his time. He was not appreciated officially for his work in genetics until as late as the 1930s.

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Mendel's discoveries were pivotal for future scientists in making further advances in the science of genetics.

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